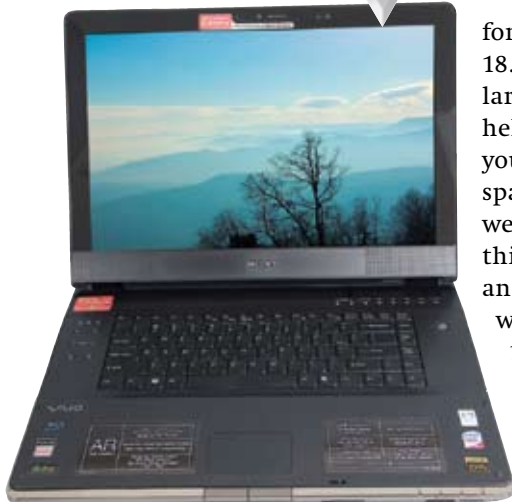




Sony Vaio VGN-AR69GU

with its premium specifications, premium performance, premium features, and its premium heritage. It's for those looking for an HTPC-cum-PC-cum-powerful notebook that is connectable to a large screen TV as well, but crave the mobile flexibility of a notebook and do not want to waste space on a desktop.

Acer Aspire 8920G

If you thought 17-inch notebooks were nicknamed "lap busters", we wonder what name would be apt

for this humongous freak. At 18.4 inches, the 8920G is the largest notebook we've seen, or held. If you're looking to lug your notebook in anything less spacious than a limousine, then we suggest you forget owning this. With a piano black finish, and a rounded, curvy posterior with a bright screen that does 1920 x 1080 pixels, this laptop isn't unattractive at all.

With 3 GB of RAM, a snappy 2.2-GHz dual-core processor and a spanking new GeForce 9500GS graphics solution, the 8920G seems to be a strong contender to replace your ageing desktop (actually, it would give any desktop a good run for its buck). For those looking for something to use as a home entertainment system, or a laptop for the entire family, you get 320 GB of HDD space, and an HDMI port to connect to your large screen TV. We'd have liked a Blu-ray optical drive, but all we got was a 20x DVD burner.

With a quirky keypad, and touch buttons that look better than they work, the 8920G is still a formidable desktop replacement solution, and it'll offer some portability to those who are muscular enough to heft its bulk around. If it loses out to the Vaio AR69GU in terms of features like a built in TV Tuner, S-Video connect and Blu-ray drive, it also wins big time in terms of price. At Rs 79,999, it's half the price of the less bulky Sony VGN-AR69GU. Although it's not as well built, and doesn't sport the same designer tag, we reckon it's a saner choice, unless you really want your notebook to grab all the attention.



Acer Aspire 8920G



How We Tested

We divided our notebooks into the following categories:

1. Notebooks up to Rs 40,000
2. Notebooks above Rs 40,000
3. Business Notebooks
4. Ultra Compact Notebooks
5. Lifestyle / Home Entertainment Notebooks

While categories 1 and 2 are crystal clear, in category 3, we included all notebooks that have a strong business orientation. Notebooks have extremely compact dimensions, up to a screen size of 13.3 inches included in the Ultra-compact category. Lifestyle notebooks are those that are powerful, with many features, but don't really cater to a particular audience.

For features, we looked at the bundle and the specifications of each laptop. We also looked at the connectivity options like the number of USB ports, FireWire, memory card readers and HDMI. We also looked for LAN, Bluetooth and WLAN connectivity.

We gave scores ranging on a scale of 10 for usability, intuitiveness, convenience as well as ergonomics. Such non-tangible factors are often what make the difference to most

users, like build quality, or the feel of a keypad, or even the placement and use of shortcut keys.

We used a clean install of Windows Vista Home Premium 32-bit, and only the drivers and necessary benchmark software were installed. For those notebooks that did not come with Windows Vista or any other Microsoft OS we used Windows XP Professional SP 2. Our tests consisted of a gamut of benchmark suites and real world tests.

To check the performance of key components like CPU, RAM, storage and video subsystems, we used two general benchmarks: PC Mark 05, and SiSoft Sandra 2007 Professional. For specifically stressing the graphics subsystem, we used 3D Mark 05. For testing the quality of the display provided, we used Display Mate's colour suite. Finally, we used WirelessMon 2.0 to check the strength of the WLAN solution embedded on each notebook.

For real world tests, we checked the overall effectiveness of each of the test subjects at viewing HD content and gaming, music, video encoding, and file transfers. The former tests stress out the video solution, CPU and memory while the file transfer test specifically targets the storage subsystem.